

February

8



1865

Genetics

Austrian monk Gregor Mendel presented his research on the inherited characteristics of pea plants to the Brünn Society for Natural Science in modern-day Czech Republic. His work led to a better understanding of human genetics.

Born this day

1828 Jules Verne, French author. He wrote many bestsellers, including *20,000 Leagues Under the Sea* and *Around the World in 80 Days*.

1672 Optics experiment

English scientist Isaac Newton showed the Royal Society in London how a prism could be used to bend sunlight and reveal its spectrum of colours. This led to the development of modern optics, the study of the behaviour of light.



1974

Stay in space

NASA's longest space mission was recorded when three US astronauts completed 84 days on the US space station Skylab. The mission demonstrated that humans could live and work in space for extended periods of time.



Also on this day

1587 After 19 years in captivity, Mary, Queen of Scots, was beheaded for her part in a plot to kill Queen Elizabeth I of England.

1841 British inventor Henry Fox Talbot patented his calotype process, the first photographic process to produce a positive image from a negative.

1904 Japan launched a torpedo attack on Port Arthur, a Russian naval base in China, triggering the Russo-Japanese War.